

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

INDIA-AFGHANISTAN - 2

MODULE - 26

1 India's efforts to provide assistance to Afghanistan are hampered considerably by the lack of geographical contiguity and limited access.

2 The prevailing security situation in Afghanistan and Pakistan's continuing interference in Afghan affairs through proxies such as the Haqqani network further disturbs the relationship

3 A strong Taliban would challenge India's security scenario in troubled Kashmir Valley.

4 Growing terrorism in Afghanistan under influence of Al Qaeda and ISIS has created security concerns for India.



- 5 The Golden Crescent, one of the most extensive opium-producing areas, and drug trafficked from Afghanistan into the Indian states like Punjab, has affected its youth and has also promoted terrorism and organized crime.
- 6 In 2011, Afghanistan and Pakistan signed Afghanistan Pakistan Trade and Transit agreement (APTTA) which has been restrictive in the bilateral trade between India and Afghanistan.
- 7 Growing Chinese influence in Afghanistan has also created a diplomatic challenge for India
- 8 India also needs to reassess its policy choices in close coordination with Russia and Iran, because Taliban poses a problem to them too



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

US-TALIBAN WAR

- 1** In 2001, after the attacks of 11 September, the US, aided by UK, allied countries and several from the NATO alliance invaded the Taliban and bombed its troops and Al-Qaeda camps.
- 2** As per reports, Taliban was harbouring Al-Qaeda terrorists, who were the main suspects of 9/11.
- 3** Since then the incumbent war is continuous in Afghanistan, where Afghan forces backed by US troops are fighting against insurgents of the Taliban.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

US-TALIBAN WAR

WHO ARE TALIBANS?

- 1 The Taliban is an extreme Sunni Islamist group operating primarily in Afghanistan and Pakistan which ruled Afghanistan from 1996 until 2001.
- 2 Its membership largely consists of religious students trained in madrasahs (Islamic religious group) in northern Pakistan.
- 3 Their aim was to impose own austere version of Islamic law on Afghanistan and to remove western influence.

- 4 They enforced strict regulation in the region related to employment and schooling for women and girls.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

US-TALIBAN WAR

- 5 In 2014, The US and NATO formally ended the combat mission in Afghanistan but continued to support Afghan forces against the Taliban.
- 6 Since 2015, Taliban's violent activities have increased. US started to make negotiations with Taliban which resulted into starting of peace process in Afghanistan.
- 7 Several rounds of talks were held between US and Taliban between 2018 and 2019 but Taliban did not allow Afghan government to be a part of such meetings as Taliban consider Afghan government as a 'puppet regime' of US.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

AFGHAN 6+1 PEACE PROCESS

- 1** From 2014 to 2016, US and Russia had quietly arranged talks on the Afghan peace process.
- 2** The meetings, known as the 6+1 group, included representatives from Afghanistan, China, India, Iran, Pakistan, Russia, and the U.S.
- 3** The 6+1 process assumed that each of these countries was essential to the achievement of a political settlement in Afghanistan.
- 4** Moreover, the U.S. and the Taliban joined for the first time a Russia-hosted conference in the hope of promoting a negotiated solution to achieve peace and national reconciliation in Afghanistan.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

INTRA AFGHAN MEETING

- 1 On 7-8 July, 2019 a two days intra Afghan meeting, sponsored by Qatar and Germany, was held in Doha, Qatar.
- 2 It was an attempt to end the Afghanistan war. It was the first such direct talk between the Afghan government and Taliban.
- 3 In April, a similar meeting was scheduled which collapsed due to disagreement between both the sides over the number of Afghan delegates.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

MAJOR OUTCOMES

Both sides agreed to frame a –

- 'Roadmap for peace'
- Work for reducing 'civilian casualties to zero'
- Assuring women their fundamental rights and think for a better political future of Afghanistan.

1 This meeting was unbind and regarded as the starting point to begin peace process in Afghanistan. Since then Taliban refused to have any intra Afghan dialogue until US agrees to withdraw their troops and release Taliban's prisoners.

2 The intra Afghan meeting was undoubtedly a positive effort yet it did not solidify anything.

3 It was regarded only as the beginning. Talks were very inclusive and representative of Afghan society but they were only dialogues and the real test will be in formal negotiations.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

US TALIBAN PEACE AGREEMENT

1 On 29 Feb, 2020 United States and Taliban signed a peace agreement in Doha, Qatar.

2 The agreement was signed after 9 rounds of talks between US and Taliban from 2018 to 2020. The provisions in the deal include –

- Withdrawal of all US and Troops from Afghanistan within 14 months.
- Taliban to remove all Al Qaeda groups from its areas.
- Taliban to resume intra Afghan dialogues with Afghan government.
- A permanent ceasefire.

Afghan government was not present during signing of this agreement. Later a scheduled peace talk between Taliban and Afghan government could not held as Afghan President Ghani refused to make a deal on prisoner swapping. Attacks from both the sides are still continue in the region.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

US TALIBAN PEACE AGREEMENT

CONCERNS

There are many concerns over the peace agreement which has been signed between US and Taliban.

1 There are speculations that Trump is ending the more than 18 year long Afghanistan war for his political gain as it was part of his election agenda. It would be considered a crucial foreign policy success for Trump which would be helpful in upcoming elections.

2 Taliban never vowed to democratic future of Afghanistan in any peace talk. It is concerned that Taliban would become even more powerful and continue its extreme violent activities in the region after the complete withdrawal of US troops.

3 There could be a civil war between religious and ethnic group.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

US TALIBAN PEACE AGREEMENT

CONCERNS

- 4 The Afghanistan women right activists are concerned that their freedom will be jeopardize after withdrawal of US troops. Their interests have not been even represented in peace talks.
- 5 The US itself remained doubtful that whether Taliban would completely remove the Al Qaeda group from its areas or not.
- 6 Taliban's commitment to ceasefire and intra Afghan talks also remains unrealistic.

- 7 For lasting peace and stability, Afghanistan forces must be given more strength and power.
- 8 Also to avoid a recurrence of civil war, a certain number of international troops must remain in Afghanistan.



Otherwise the country will become a hub of terrorism

PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

QUADRILATERAL COORDINATION GROUP (QCG)

- 1 Quadrilateral Coordination Group (QCG) is a four-nation group comprising Afghanistan, China, Pakistan and the United States of America, working for reconciliation in Afghanistan
- 2 It aims to initiate reconciliation process between civilian government in Afghanistan and Taliban to preserve Afghanistan's unity, sovereignty and territorial integrity and achieve lasting peace and stability in Afghanistan and the region.



PEACE PROCESS IN AFGHANISTAN

QUADRILATERAL COORDINATION GROUP (QCG)

SHORTCOMINGS

- 1 The success of QCG depends on Taliban's reconciliation which seems challenging given the continued violent attacks by Taliban. Pakistan has been providing a safe haven to the Taliban.
- 2 The group does not include Russia which knows Afghanistan, its politics and actors better. It instead includes China, which though a regional power but does not have much insight.
- 3 Pakistan and Afghanistan need to cooperate for its proper functioning.
- 4 The group excludes Iran and India which are not only allies of Afghanistan but also have stake in peace and security of the region.

India has always held reservations about the success of talks with the Taliban, especially the Quadrilateral Coordination Group (QCG)



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

PAKISTAN FACTOR

1 Pakistani political leaders and the army are of the opinion that any Indian involvement in Afghanistan is inimical to Pakistan's interests.

2 Pakistan has also used Taliban and other terrorist outfits as its proxy to counter India in Afghanistan.

3 Pakistan has also created hurdles in bilateral trade between India and Afghanistan through Afghanistan Pakistan Trade and Transit agreement.

4 Pakistan allows Afghan trucks carrying goods meant for India only up to its last check point at Wagah and not to Indian check point at Attari, less than a km away.



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

SHIFT IN US POLICY

- 1** US President Barack Obama ordered a full-scale review of the USA's Afghanistan policy. US President Trump, however, indicated a significant shift in USA's Afghan Policy.
- 2** His initial decisions to deepen the country's military engagement in Afghanistan signalled that the war against terror will continue and there may be an increase in number of US troops deployed in Afghanistan.
- 3** India's role in Afghanistan was fully acknowledged by US and it called out for a more proactive role of India in Afghanistan.



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

SHIFT IN US POLICY

- 4 This shift in USA's policy has shown a greater convergence of interests between India and US when it comes to Pakistan and its links with terrorism.
- 5 However, there have been concerns that a closer partnership between India and USA on counterterrorism may trigger further hostilities between India and Pakistan and lead to greater Chinese interference in Pakistan's favour, as a counterbalance to American and Indian efforts.
- 6 US cannot achieve its objectives in Afghanistan without the support of the Pakistan military.
- 7 Porous Durand Line and the logistics-heavy requirements of the US military, makes supplies through Pakistan (in the absence of an alternative route) indispensable.



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

CHINA'S POSTURES

1 China has entered the Afghan-Pak region and increased its presence through its One Belt One Road Initiative

2 Aimed at expanding its strategic footprint alongside its economic clout, OBOR poses direct challenges to US interests.

3 Afghanistan is willing to integrate into the regional connectivity approach and they are willing to integrate into the CPEC.

4 Some OBOR projects have involved Chinese military deployments to ensure security, though Beijing has denied previous reports of its troops being active in Afghanistan

5 Chinese Foreign Minister made the remark of opening the door for Kabul's entry in an expanded CPEC in the backdrop of the first foreign minister's trilateral dialogue of China, Pakistan, and Afghanistan.



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

CHINA'S POSTURES

- 6 The Afghan President Ghani paid his first overseas visit into China in 2014 and the ties between Kabul and Beijing increased.
- 7 India is unhappy with this development.
- 8 Presently, China is Afghanistan's third-largest trading partner, with bilateral trade reaching over \$1 billion by 2015.
- 9 Chinese President Xi Jinping and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi agreed to cooperate in Afghanistan and on work on joint projects at the Wuhan Summit in April 2018.



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

WAY FORWARD FOR INDIA-AFGHANISTAN RELATIONS

- India's national interests lie in a peaceful and stable Afghanistan.
- Therefore, India should support all initiatives towards improving the security situation in Afghanistan and promoting peace and prosperity in the war-torn country.

- 1 India should remain committed towards the elimination of terrorism from Afghanistan and the destruction of all sanctuaries of the anti-India terrorist outfits.
- 2 India should continue to provide aid and assistance to the government and the people of Afghanistan.
- 3 India should also continue its developmental efforts in Afghanistan especially training its security forces and building its infrastructure to maintain peace and prosperity.



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

WAY FORWARD FOR INDIA-AFGHANISTAN RELATIONS

4 India should also help Afghanistan to attain strategic autonomy and free itself from the clutches of Pakistani leadership.

5 The strategic location of Afghanistan between South Asia and Central Asia offers India a great opportunity to boost its trade with Central Asia through Chabahar route.

6 India should ensure expeditious implementation of the trilateral agreement involving Iran which would use Chabahar port to augment connectivity in the region.

7 Efforts of India's Afghan policy should also take into account its energy security, for example, through the commissioning of the TAPI pipeline.



CHALLENGES IN THE PEACE PROCESS AND INDIA-AFGHAN RELATIONS

WAY FORWARD FOR INDIA-AFGHANISTAN RELATIONS

- 8 Ties between Afghanistan and its neighbors, including Iran, will impact the security of southern and western Asia.
- 9 Like India, Russia, China and the U.S, a stable Afghanistan is in Iran's interest. India can build on its good ties with the U.S. and Iran to secure Afghanistan.
- 10 India enjoys ample goodwill among the bureaucracy and the people of Afghanistan which can be leveraged to build strong ties with Afghanistan.



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